

Chapter Twenty-Four

Both Truths

Nora arrived at the garden at 11:58.

Two minutes early.

Not an accident.

Not a failure.

A compromise between the woman who wanted to arrive thirty minutes early and the woman who was trying to trust that noon would come without being watched into existence.

The old church garden was damp from morning rain. Water gathered on the bench beneath the fig tree in small silver beads. The rosemary bushes had survived the cold with bitter dignity. The saint in the corner held her weather-worn palms open, as if still receiving prayers she had no intention of answering directly.

Nora stood by the gate.

She did not sit.

She had learned this about herself: waiting felt different depending on posture. Sitting too soon made her feel abandoned when no one arrived immediately. Standing reminded her that she was still in her own body, still capable of choosing whether to stay.

At noon exactly, Maya entered.

Nora saw her through the gate and felt the month move through her like a physical thing.

Maya looked tired.

Not hospital-tired only. Different. As if the truth about Isabel had added a new room to her life and she had spent weeks walking through it in the dark, touching walls she had not known existed.

Her hair was loose under a dark scarf. Her coat was buttoned wrong, one button shifted into the wrong hole. Nora noticed and did not reach to fix it.

That was love now.

Seeing.

Not taking.

Maya stopped a few feet away.

“Hi,” she said.

“Hi.”

They looked at each other like people meeting after a storm that had not ended, only moved inland.

Maya’s eyes lowered to Nora’s hands. “You’re not holding your phone.”

Nora glanced down, surprised. Her hands were empty.

“It’s in my pocket.”

“That feels significant.”

“It feels terrifying.”

Maya’s mouth twitched.

A smile almost happened.

Almost.

Then she looked at the bench. “It’s wet.”

“I know.”

“Did you bring tissues?”

“Yes.”

“Of course you did.”

“And a plastic bag.”

Maya blinked. “For what?”

“To sit on. Because the bench is wet.”

Maya stared at her.

Then, unexpectedly, laughed.

The sound was small but real, and Nora felt it enter her chest with such force that she nearly cried.

“Prepared but not controlling,” Maya said.

“That was the goal.”

“Fine. Excellent boundary-compliant plastic bag.”

Nora pulled it from her pocket and spread it over the bench. Maya sat on one side. Nora sat on the other.

There was space between them.

Less than before.

Still enough.

For a while, neither spoke.

The garden held them in its cold quiet.

Then Maya said, “I met Isabel in a café.”

Nora’s hands tightened in her lap.

She did not ask which café.

Did not ask what Isabel wore.

Did not ask if Isabel looked like Maya.

Did not ask if Isabel hated her.

Maya watched her not asking.

Her expression changed.

“Thank you,” she said.

Nora swallowed. “For what?”

“For not grabbing the details out of the air.”

The sentence hurt and healed at once.

Nora nodded.

Maya looked toward the old church wall. “She looks like my father.”

Nora closed her eyes briefly.

A detail.

Given.

She let it rest in her hands without reaching for more.

“More than I do,” Maya continued. “That was the first awful thing. I walked in and thought, oh. There he is. In a person I never knew existed.”

Nora listened.

“She was already there. Early. Sitting with her back to the wall like she wanted to see the whole room.” Maya gave a faint, sad smile. “You would have understood that.”

Nora’s throat tightened.

“Maybe.”

“She ordered tea and didn’t drink it. I ordered coffee and drank too much. We were both trying to look less nervous than we were, which made us look insane.”

Despite herself, Nora smiled.

Maya’s fingers picked at the edge of her sleeve.

“She was angry,” she said. “Not loudly. I think I expected loud. I expected her to accuse me of having everything. And maybe she does think that. Maybe she has the right. But mostly she was... controlled.”

Nora thought of the cold bedroom.

The returned letters.

The folder.

The way Isabel's anger had lived organized because no one had given it a room.

She said nothing.

Maya looked at her.

For one second, Nora wondered if Maya could see the stolen knowledge on her face.

Maybe she could.

Maybe some damage remained visible even after silence.

Maya continued. "She asked about Dad. Then said she didn't know whether she had the right to call him that. Dad." She laughed once, painfully. "I didn't know what to say because I've been calling him that my whole life without thinking it was a privilege."

Nora's eyes burned.

"Maya."

Maya shook her head gently. Not stopping her. Not rejecting comfort. Just asking for room to continue.

"I told her about Mom. Not everything. Just enough. She told me about her mother. Not everything. Just enough." Maya looked down. "There was so much enough in that conversation. Enough to hurt. Not enough to understand."

"That sounds hard."

"It was."

A bird landed on the edge of the fountain, looked offended by the lack of water, and flew away.

Maya watched it go.

“Then she asked about you.”

Nora stopped breathing.

Maya turned to her.

“I told her you were my sister.”

Nora’s eyes filled immediately.

Maya’s did too.

“Not like before,” Maya said. “Not as a comparison. Not as defense. I told her you were my sister because that is true. And I told her you hurt me because that is also true.”

Nora nodded, unable to speak.

“She didn’t ask for details. She said she preferred not to know for now.”

“She texted me,” Nora said quietly.

Maya’s face changed.

“When?”

“Two days ago. She said she knew something happened. I apologized. I told her she didn’t owe me anything. She asked for no further contact for now.”

Maya absorbed that.

“You respected it?”

“Yes.”

Maya looked at her for a long moment.

The month sat between them, not erased but witnessed.

“Thank you,” Maya said.

Nora wiped beneath one eye. “I should have respected it before she had to ask.”

“Yes,” Maya said.

The answer was not cruel.

It was true.

Nora took it.

Maya looked down at her hands.

“I need to say something that may hurt.”

Nora breathed in.

“Okay.”

“I don’t trust you the way I did.”

The sentence landed heavily, even though Nora had expected it.

Maybe expectation did not soften truth.

“I know,” Nora said, then corrected herself. “I understand.”

Maya’s mouth trembled slightly.

“I believe you are trying. I believe the month mattered. I believe you did hard things. But trust is not a switch I can turn back on because you suffered correctly.”

Nora closed her eyes.

There was no defense.

No defense would have deserved the room.

“I don’t want you to trust me before you do,” she said.

Maya looked at her.

Nora continued, slowly. “That would only make me feel better. It wouldn’t make you safe.”

Maya’s eyes filled again.

“See,” she said quietly, “that is exactly the kind of thing that makes me want to trust you.”

Nora gave a broken laugh. “That feels unfair.”

“It is.”

They sat in silence.

Then Maya said, “I missed you.”

Nora covered her mouth.

Maya looked away quickly, as if the confession embarrassed her.

“I missed you and I was angry every time I missed you,” Maya said. “I would see something stupid and want to send it to you. Then I’d remember. Then I’d get furious that missing you made me feel disloyal to myself.”

Nora cried silently.

“I missed you too,” she said.

“I know.”

This time, Maya said it.

And it did not hurt.

Maya wiped her cheeks with the heel of her hand. “Dad is home.”

“I’m glad.”

“He’s impossible.”

“I’m also glad about that.”

“He asked about you.”

Nora went still.

Maya smiled faintly. “He said, ‘Where is the pear criminal?’”

A laugh escaped Nora, wet and surprised.

“Tell him I remain at large.”

“I will.”

“Or don’t. If that’s not—”

“Nora.”

“Right. Sorry.”

Maya’s smile softened. “I can tell him that.”

Nora nodded.

“Thank you.”

Maya leaned back against the bench. “Mom asks about you too.”

Nora’s chest ached.

“I miss them.”

“I know.”

Nora looked at her.

Maya shrugged. “You became family loudly. There are consequences.”

The warmth of that almost undid her.

Then Maya’s face grew serious again.

“But I’m not ready for you to come over yet.”

Nora nodded immediately.

“Okay.”

“I mean it.”

“I know. I mean, I understand.”

Maya watched her.

Then she laughed softly. “You’re editing yourself in real time.”

“It is exhausting.”

“It looks exhausting.”

“It is also safer.”

“Yes,” Maya said. “It is.”

A gust of wind moved through the garden. The fig branches knocked softly against each other.

Nora rubbed her hands together for warmth.

Maya noticed.

This time, she did not offer gloves.

Maybe she had learned too.

Maybe they both had.

“What do you want from this conversation?” Maya asked.

Nora looked at her, startled.

The question was clear. Direct. Adult.

Difficult.

“I want to ask for everything back,” Nora said.

Maya’s face shifted.

Nora continued before fear could make the sentence prettier. “I want you to say the month is over and we’re okay and I can come to your apartment and sit too close and send stupid messages and be the person you call first. I want to be forgiven in a way that makes me stop feeling what I did.”

Maya’s eyes shone.

“But that’s not what I’m asking for,” Nora said.

“What are you asking for?”

“One conversation after this one,” Nora said. “When you’re ready. No timeline. Just... not the last.”

Maya looked down.

The silence stretched.

Nora let it.

Finally, Maya nodded.

“One conversation after this one.”

Nora exhaled shakily.

“Thank you.”

“What do you want from this conversation?” Nora asked.

Maya seemed surprised to be asked back.

She thought for a while.

“I wanted to see if I felt afraid sitting beside you.”

Nora went cold.

“And?” she asked.

Maya looked at her.

“Yes,” she said.

Nora nodded.

The word hurt less than a lie would have.

Maya continued, “But not only afraid.”

Nora swallowed.

“What else?”

Maya’s voice softened.

“Sad. Angry. Relieved. Homesick.”

“Homesick?”

Maya nodded.

“For us.”

The sentence entered the garden like a bell.

Nora looked away because looking at Maya while hearing it was too much.

“I’m homesick too,” she whispered.

Maya sniffed. “I hate this.”

“I know.”

“You’re allowed that one.”

Nora laughed through tears.

Then Maya reached into her coat pocket and pulled out a folded piece of paper.

Nora’s body tensed.

Maya saw.

“It’s not from Isabel,” she said.

Nora relaxed slightly.

“It’s from me.”

She handed it over.

Nora looked at it but did not open it.

“What is it?”

“A list.”

That surprised a laugh out of Nora.

“I thought I was the list person.”

“You infected me.”

“My apologies.”

“Accepted conditionally.”

Nora held the paper carefully.

Maya said, “It’s what I need if we keep trying. Not all forever. Just for now.”

Nora’s fingers tightened.

“Can I read it here?”

“Yes.”

Nora unfolded the paper.

Maya’s handwriting filled the page, slanted and familiar.

For now:

1. If you feel pressure connected to me, tell me as soon as possible. Do not hide it to protect me from fear.
2. If you jump into me, tell me that it happened, but do not tell me what you saw unless I ask.
3. If I ask for space, do not argue with the request while it is happening. We can discuss it later.
4. Do not contact Isabel unless she contacts you first or I explicitly say it is okay.
5. Do not ask Adam for information about me unless I have agreed.
6. If you feel replaced, say “I feel replaced” instead of searching for proof.
7. I am allowed to love other people without it being evidence against me.
8. You are allowed to hurt without making someone guilty.
9. We are sisters if we both keep choosing it.
10. Choosing it may look different now.

Nora read the list once.

Then again.

By the third time, the words blurred.

Number nine broke her.

We are sisters if we both keep choosing it.

Maya watched her silently.

Nora folded the paper carefully along its original crease.

“I can agree to all of this,” she said.

Maya’s mouth trembled.

“But?” Maya asked.

“No but.” Nora held the paper against her chest. “Only that agreeing is the beginning, not proof.”

Maya closed her eyes.

“Good answer.”

“Do I get a grade?”

“No.”

“Fair.”

Maya laughed softly.

Then Nora reached into her own coat pocket.

“I brought something too.”

Maya stiffened.

“It’s not emotional contraband,” Nora said quickly.

Maya gave her a look.

Nora pulled out a small notebook.

Plain cover. Blue. New.

“I started using BORDERS for myself. It helped. But it’s full of things that are mine, and I don’t want to turn it into another document I use to prove I’m improving.” She held out the

notebook. “This is empty. I thought maybe, if you want, it could be ours. Not for secrets. For agreements. Things said clearly. Things we are allowed to revise.”

Maya stared at the notebook.

Nora added quickly, “You don’t have to take it. It might be too much. Or too weird. Or too—”

Maya took it.

Nora stopped.

Maya turned it over in her hands.

“An agreement book,” she said.

“That sounds very formal.”

“It sounds like friendship paperwork.”

“Sisterhood paperwork.”

Maya looked up.

Nora’s heart stopped.

Then Maya nodded once.

“Sisterhood paperwork.”

The words were tentative.

But there.

Maya opened to the first page.

“Do you have a pen?”

“Obviously.”

Nora handed her one.

Maya wrote at the top of the page:

We are not trying to go back.
We are trying to go forward without pretending back did not happen.

She turned the notebook toward Nora.

Nora read it.

Then took the pen and added:

No one gets access to the other person by suffering hard enough.

Maya read it and winced.

“Good,” she said.

“Too harsh?”

“No. Good.”

She took the pen again.

Being chosen is real.

Nora’s breath caught.

Maya looked at her.

Then added:

Being blood is real too.

Nora nodded.

Both truths.

Both.

Nora took the pen.

One does not erase the other.

Maya’s eyes filled.

She closed the notebook gently.

“That’s enough for today,” she said.

“Yes.”

They sat with the closed notebook between them.

Not a bridge exactly.

Not yet.

A plank laid carefully over dangerous water.

Maya checked the time and sighed.

“I need to go. Mom has an appointment, and Dad believes being left alone for thirty minutes is government oppression.”

“He remains consistent.”

“He does.”

Maya stood.

Nora stood too.

For a moment, they faced each other.

No hug had been promised.

No touch requested.

Nora kept her hands at her sides.

Maya looked at them.

Then at Nora.

“I want to,” Maya said.

Nora’s eyes filled.

“But not today?” Nora asked.

Maya nodded, crying again. “Not today.”

“Okay.”

Maya pressed the notebook against her chest.

“One conversation after this one,” she said.

“One conversation after this one,” Nora echoed.

Maya turned and walked toward the gate.

This time, Nora did not stay seated.

She did not follow either.

She only stood where she was.

At the gate, Maya looked back.

Not long.

Enough.

Then she left.

Nora remained in the garden until the cold reached her bones.

Only then did she take out her phone.

She texted Adam.

Alive. No pressure. We met. It was hard. Not bad. No details unless Maya says okay.

His reply came a few minutes later.

Received. I’m glad it was not bad. Are you okay?

Nora considered.

Then wrote:

Both yes and no.

Adam replied:

Both truths.

Nora smiled through tears.

She looked around the garden.

The bench.

The fig tree.

The saint with open hands.

So many things had happened here. Accusation. Confession. Grief.
Rules. Collapse. Restraint. Distance. Return.

The place had held all of it without becoming only one thing.

Maybe people could do that too.

Maybe sisterhood could.

Maybe love could.

Not by pretending the damage had not happened.

By learning to carry more than one truth without using one to kill
the other.

Nora slipped Maya's list carefully into her coat pocket.

Then she walked home.

The pressure did not come.

No doors opened.

No one called from the other side.

But as Nora passed the flower shop on her way back, she saw a
new arrangement in the window: white tulips, eucalyptus, and a
single branch painted silver.

Maya's work.

Nora stopped.

Looked.

Did not enter.

Did not text.

Only witnessed.

Inside the shop, someone had made something beautiful and set it near the glass for strangers to see.

Nora let that be enough.

Then she kept walking.

DaintyHub